Nonprofit Technology, Architecture, and AI Enablement:

Six Themes Shaping the Next 1–3 Years

SYNC 2026 | Closing Keynote | Jim Funari, CEO

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Six Themes Shaping the Next 1–3 Years

1. User Experience Will Become Simpler, More Diverse, and More Tailored
2. Best-of-Breed Stacks Will Face Pressure from Integrated Platforms
3. Horizontal CRM Vendors Remain Strong, But Vertical Pressure Is Growing
4. AI Will Move from Assistance to Action
5. Data Unification Will Determine the Quality of Personalization
6. The Promise: Simplicity, Trust, and Measurable Impact

1 UX Will Become Simpler, More Diverse, and More Tailored

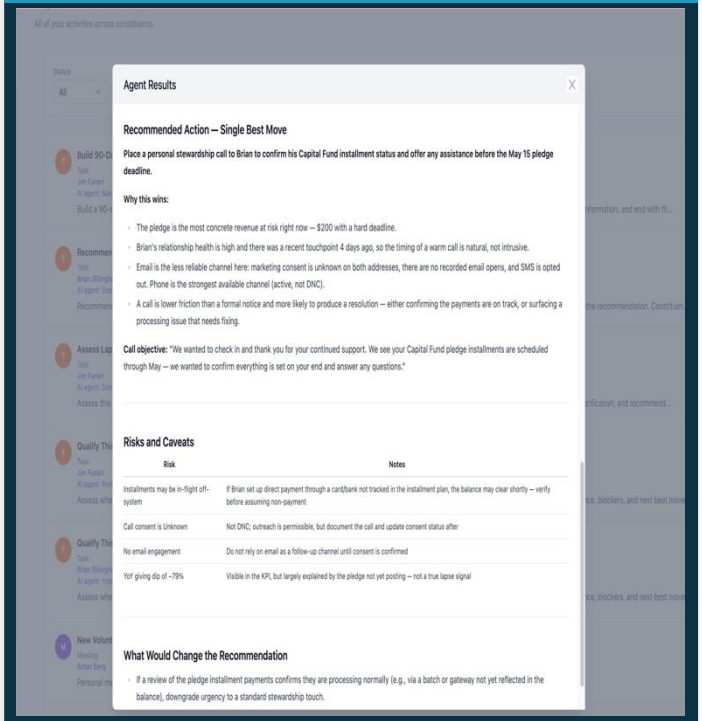
Rigid, form-heavy systems are giving way to **guided, conversational, role-conversational, role-based workflows.**

Development, volunteers, programs, leadership, finance — each role needs role needs its own experience, not a generic screen.

Simpler UX means less training, faster adoption, and more time spent on spent on mission.

"The interface of the future is not a form; it is a guided experience."

Ignite Intelligence — Guided Agent in Action



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Constituents
Workspace

Search... Ctrl+K

- Home

MY WORK
- My Activities
- Calendar Sync

CONSTITUENTS
- Profiles
- Segments
- Engagement Insights
- Automations
- Reports & Analytics
- Query Builder
- Setup

Jim Funari
View profile

CONSTITUENTS > PROFILES > Recent/Pinned ⌘J

Brian Billingham

Individual | Pin

Contact | Edit

CONTACT

bbham1@hotmail.com
Primary — Personal

+17573200348
Primary — Mobile

7712 Carlton Pl
McLean, VA 22102

KEY STATS | Refresh

LIFETIME	AVG GIFT
$575	$97
LAST GIFT	**HEALTH**
Mar	high
ENGAGEMENT	**NEXT GIFT**
45 low	Apr 70%

TAGS | + Add

No tags assigned

Overview | Timeline | Dona | Pin

Insights

AI-generated research and analysis linked to this constituent.

All types

Prospect Research
Apr 19, 2026 8:51 PM

2026 Capital Campaign — Qualification Note: Brian Billingham

AI-assisted qualification brief for the 2026 Capital Campaign. Credible prospect; qualification visit recommended before advancing to a $50,000 ask.

PROSPECT RESEARCH AGENT

View details

Prospect Research
Apr 19, 2026 8:27 PM

Recommended Ask Strategy — Brian Billingham

Campaign context: 2026 Capital Campaign

PROSPECT RESEARCH AGENT

View details | Chat

Donna for Retention
Retention Agent

Context: Brian Billingham
/organizations/4-H/constituents/profiles/0199ed8e-ae52-7d43-b00d-d65c67f73387

Donna for Retention
Hello! How can I help?

Ask Donna for Retention...

What can you help me with?
Tell me about your capabilities | Get started

Playbooks runs in background

- Summarize Donor Retention Status
- Assess Lapse Risk
- Recommend Retention Action
- Recover Failed Recurring Payment
- Identify Upgrade Readiness
- Find Donors Needing Attention
- Identify Reactivation Opportunities

2 Integrated Platforms Will Outperform Best-of-Breed Stacks

Separate tools fragment the context that personalization depends on.

Real personalization requires shared data, shared workflows, and a shared intelligence layer.

Engagement, truth, and intelligence must operate as one — not as three.

"AI works best when it sits on top of a trusted data backbone, not beside it."

System of Engagement

Fundraising · Marketing · Events · Volunteers · Donation Pages

System of Intelligence

AI Agents · Analytics · Scoring · Guided Actions

System of Truth

CRM · Finance · Relationships · History · Self-Service

3 Horizontal CRM Vendors Remain Strong, But Vertical Specialty Wins

Large orgs with strong IT teams get real value from horizontal platforms — the breadth, ecosystem, and scale are genuine assets.

Smaller nonprofits pay the complexity tax without the internal capacity to absorb it.

Purpose-built platforms win on time to value, clearer economics, and native nonprofit workflows.

Dimension	Horizontal Platforms	Purpose-Built Vertical
Enterprise Fit	Strong — broad ecosystem, enterprise IT depth	Emerging — increasingly viable with modern architecture
Mid-Market Fit	Strained — complexity and cost exceed capacity	Strong — purpose-built workflows, faster adoption, clearer clearer economics
Nonprofit Workflows	Partial — shaped by commercial B2B priorities	Native — fundraising, stewardship, & gift management built-in management built-in

"Larger organizations can absorb complexity; smaller organizations often cannot."

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4 AI Will Move from Assistance to Action

Yesterday	Today	Now	Next
AI Assists	**AI Creates**	**AI Recommends**	**AI Executes**
Spell-check. Grammar fix. Basic templates.	Email drafts. Summarization. Meeting notes.	Donor insights. Next best action. Workflow routing.	Agents that act. Human oversight. At scale.

"AI has the potential to significantly expand nonprofit capacity, improve decision-making, and deepen mission impact."

5 Data Unification Will Determine the Quality of Personalization

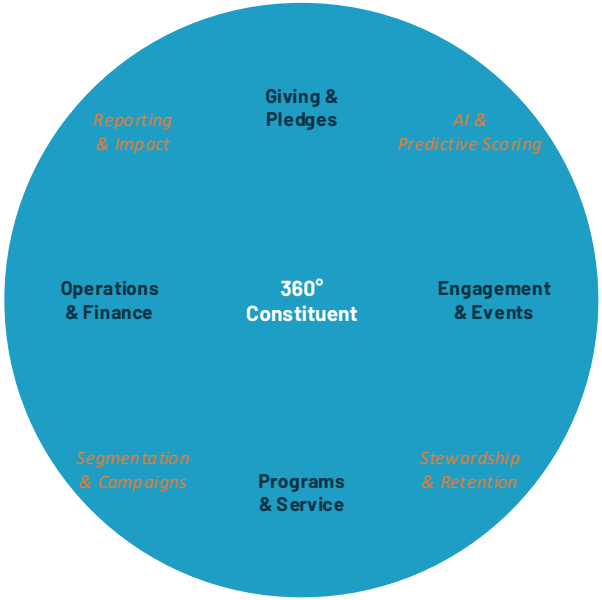
Personalization requires a unified view — giving, engagement, service, and operations in one place.

AI is only as good as the data beneath it.

A true 360-degree constituent model drives better retention, stewardship, and mission impact.

"Organizations must measure impact, not just activity."

The 360° Constituent Model



6 The Promise: Simplicity, Trust, and Measurable Impact

Simplicity

Nonprofits will favor solutions that are easy to adopt, easy to govern, and easy to measure.

- Consumer-grade UX with guided workflows
- Configure, not customize
- Role-based, not generic screens
- Fast time to value

Trust

Boards, donors, and staff require accountability. accountability. The platform must be governable, governable, auditable, and secure.

- Transparent data model
- AI actions that are reviewable
- Reliable uptime and compliance
- Vendor stability and commitment

Measurable Impact

Success will be judged by donor retention, staff productivity, stewardship quality, program delivery, and operational efficiency.

- Donor retention and upgrade rates
- Staff productivity recovered
- Stewardship quality and response time
- Mission delivery efficiency

"The missing link is not another tool. It is a better operating model."

The next generation of nonprofit software will not win by being broader.

It will win by being more integrated, more intelligent,

and more mission-specific.

The real payoff is capacity:

helping organizations do more with the team they have — so they can raise more, deliver more, and create more outcomes.

Your Next Actions

Three ways to move forward from what you saw at SYNC 2026.

1

TALK WITH BRENDAN, ALICIA, BRETT

Have a conversation with your Client Success Team. Experience the Ignite platform firsthand — core modules, agent capabilities, and Playbooks in a guided demos.

2

ENROLL IN CLIENT EVALUATION PROGRAM

Shape the migration framework, timeline, and tools together with us — built with you, not announced to you.

3

ATTEND WEBINARS

Participate in upcoming webinars, product overviews, demonstrations, and client cohorts.

"Your migration path will be built with you, not announced to you." — Opening Keynote, Our Commitments #4

***Thank you** for joining us at SYNC 2026!*

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